

Kavita Menon

kavita.menon@thehindu.co.in

After navigating a handful of twists and turns, much like cars on a racetrack, the excitement was building for the remaining six races — and quite understandably so. There were new race winners, new championship leaders, and, for the first time in a long while, a thrilling fight for the title, with six races and three sprints left before the curtain falls on the 2024 season.

The unfamiliar four-week autumn break had cooled things down, but there were still plenty of discussions in the paddock, including the departure of eight-time race winner Daniel Ricciardo and the scrapping of the fastest lap point from 2025. Despite a lot of off-track chatter, F1 headed to Austin for the United States Grand Prix, the first stop of the triple-header, with all eyes on the battle ahead, as a maximum of 36 points were up for grabs.

It might have felt nostalgic for Max Verstappen to clinch pole position after a 109-day gap, breaking free from a winless streak in his otherwise dominant Red Bull. The defending champion steadily pulled ahead of the pack during the sprint race, finishing atop the podium, most importantly ahead of Lando Norris. There was plenty of on-track action during the 19-lap sprint, setting the stage for a thrilling race on Sunday.

Such is the nature of the Circuit of the Americas, which allows cars to go side-by-side through its wide corners, that it provides numerous opportunities for overtaking. Four teams almost matched each other in pace. Three of them — McLaren, Mercedes, and Red Bull — brought upgrade packages, while Ferrari arrived at the weekend with an unchanged car.

Perhaps all the Italian team needed was a change of scenery and a chance to rise to the occasion, as the Ferrari duo of Charles Leclerc and Carlos Sainz left their competitors in the dust, securing a 1-2 finish after nearly seven months. The last time

Picturesque: Charles Leclerc after winning the US Grand Prix. GETTY IMAGES

AUSTIN BLEEDS RED

Ferrari's Charles Leclerc and Carlos Sainz clinched a **thrilling 1-2 finish**, while Max Verstappen strengthened his lead at the top.